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Name of the Author : TRISTAN VEZIO

Name of the Professor who will grade it : Lurdes VIDAL

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“Bread, freedom, and human dignity!” proclaimed Ahmed Fouad Negm, the Egyptian poet whose verses, delivered by Sheikh Imam, Egyptian singer, became the anthem of the oppressed under Nasser and then Sadat. Decades earlier, Nizar Qabbani, the “poet of Damascus,” had already transformed the Arab revolt into art, denouncing in *The Book of Love* (1961) a society *“where tyrants write history with blood.”*. Fifty years later, a new wave of protest,which later became the Arab Spring, erupted .The Arab States and Governments reacted with unwavering determination and resilience: suppression, integration, and innovation of their governing methods in order to survive, often using the classical tools of an authoritarian regime : force. What accounts for the phenomenon whereby societies steeped in traditions of both literary and popular dissent continue to be confined by such persistent authoritarian systems still nowadays? How can we explain the long survival of Authoritarianism in the Region ?

It's key, to define and distinguish, two key elements that will be constantly present in our analysis : Authoritarianism and Authoritarian resilience. Authoritarianism is defined by an extreme concentration of power, a restricted political pluralism, and the concrete absence of political pluralism (Linz 2000 ; Gandhi & Przeworski 2007). However, authoritarian resilience tackles the ability of regimes to survive, despite the crisis, coping with international pressure, and reproducing their domination, by coercive mechanisms and institutional adaptation (Bellin, 2004). The Arab World seems to embody a political paradox. Despite the 3rd Wave of democratization (Huntington, 1991), and the 2011 Uprising in the region, which suggested the possibility of a new fourth wave of democratization, following the Arab Springs, the vast majority of regimes, not only persisted but emerged stronger, refining their tools for control. While globally human rights and democratic standards have been in retreat, the MENA region has been particularly effective at neutralizing popular aspirations for reform. Data from the Arab Barometer, in 2022, and 2023 also highlight a striking dissonance : 82% of young Arabs aspire to democracy, but political structures systematically crush those aspirations, and block the path to reforms. Our essay will state that Arab authoritarianism survives not due to cultural incompatibility with democracy, but because of institutionalized, adaptive, and resource-backed mechanisms — yet its endurance is not guaranteed indefinitely, notably via coercion. Utilizing a comparative framework, this essay relies on case analyses (Egypt, Syria, Gulf monarchies), an assessment of scholarly writings (Bellin 2004; Heydemann 2013), and information sourced from empirical studies (Arab Barometer, reports from the Arab Reform Initiative). Following an exploration of culturally influenced rationales , we will evaluate the impact of coercive strategies, economies characterized by rent-seeking behavior and methods of authoritarian adaptation The final section will address the ability of these regimes to manage the emergent structural pressures of the 21st century.

II. Cultural vs Structural Explanations

Another debate—less prevalent in policy papers but prominent in historiography, particularly in the late 1990s—concerns the culturalist approach, which explains the persistence of authoritarianism in the Arab region from a Western perspective.

Scholars, such as Elie Kedouri, British historian, or Bernard Lewis, argue that democracy is largely foreign to Arab political traditions.Liberal constitutionalism would naturally lead to democracy. Limited and parliamentary experiences in Egypt and Syria during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries are frequently referred to as indicators of the inability of democratic institutions to establish themselves, as communal, tribal, or sectarian affiliations took precedence over civic nationalism. Viewed in this manner, the endurance of authoritarianism is seen as a manifestation of entrenched cultural norms rather than merely situational political frameworks. However, in this debate, how could we explain the 1988 riots, in Algeria, against the FLN (Front de Libération Nationale) and the 'first' democratic experiences, or the experience of multipartism in Yemen in the 1990s ? More recently, if cultural elements were decisive, it would be impossible to explain the 2011 events that demanded for social justice, and accountable governments aligned with the democratic demands. The case of Bahrain, is particularly symptomatic. In 2011, in a context of large-scale protests, majorities led from the Shi'a citizens, demanded political opening, including constitutional reform and representative governance. Although the movement was ultimately suppressed, it was not defeated because of 'supposed incompatibility' with democracy and Shi'a political culture. Instead, it was crushed by geopolitics and external interventionism. The military intervention of Saudi Arabia, and other Gulf Cooperation Council States, made the aspiration impossible. Geopolitical calculations and coercive capacity—not religious identity—determined the outcome. Democracy was blocked by regime survival strategies and regional authoritarian solidarity.

However, and as Larry Diamond (2010) argues, no culture is inherently incompatible with democracy; instead, institutional configurations and power relations explain regime outcome. Diversity within the Arab region itself weakens cultural interpretations. The persistence of authoritarianism is more accurately comprehended through institutional robustness, coercive unity, and the influences of political economy. While culture can influence political dialogue, it does not dictate the form of governance. The sustainability of authoritarian regimes is based on structural factors rather than civilizational aspects. Resilience is structural and not cultural.

III. The Coercive Apparatus: Military and Security

Among our structural elements, we could easily argue that the coercitive apparatus is the most decisive, especially in scholars' debate and analysis. In her article, Eva Bellin (2004) argues that the tenacity of authoritarianism in the Middle East can be explained by the will and capacity of military, and, security forces of the State to repress. Following her analysis, regimes do not fall, when societies mobilize, but coercive institutions refuse or are unable to suppress them. She even categorizes four key variables that define this "capacity" :financial stability (assets to finance oppression), institutional development (cohesiveness and professionalism of the organization), global backing, and allegiance of the elite.
This argument can be further strengthened through the power-centered approach of Ferran Izquierdo Brichs. In his sociological framework regarding power, Izquierdo Brichs asserts that the endurance of political entities hinges on the monopolization and regulation of

essential resources—namely, coercive, economic, and symbolic assets. Authoritarian leaders persist when they effectively manage these resources while obstructing their adversaries from obtaining them. Thus, the mechanisms of coercion are not simply tools for oppression; rather, they constitute the fundamental foundation through which governing coalitions maintain their supremacy and oversee rivalry among elites (Brichs,2007). A key example of this insight, could be Egypt. Armed forces, which hold political power, and the security sector, are a key economic actor, integrated within Al-Sissi apparatus. Their independent operations and financial interests are closely linked to the survival of the regime. In 2013, when protests challenged President Morsi's authority, the military stepped in, leading to Abdel Fattah el-Sisi's ascension to power. The massacre at Rabaa in 2013, revealed the regime's readiness to resort to severe violence to suppress dissent. The introduction of laws against protests and constitutional changes that enhanced executive authority solidified authoritarian governance. The factors identified by Bellin are evident: robust institutionalization, financial support (including assistance from the Gulf), international forbearance, and unity among elites. According to Izquierdo Brichs, the military's control over both force and economic assets inhibited elite division and mitigated threats from civilian opponents. Beyond general authoritarianism in the Arab region, the coercive apparatus often integrates surveillance and a close alliance between political and military elites. For instance, the purges within the Baas party, in 1979 under Sadam Hussein, or, more recently, in 2017-2019, the purges within the army and administration in Saudi-Arabia, under Mohammad Bin Salman rule, under the excuse of anti-bribery fight. In Syria, the regime of Bashar al-Assad relied on a security apparatus built on loyalist networks embedded in elite military and intelligence units. When protests erupted in 2011, it responded with systematic repression. Elite cohesion prevented major defections, while a war economy and decisive backing from Russia and Iran offset fiscal decline. International support thus reinforced both Bellin's variable of external backing and Izquierdo Brichs' logic of resource monopolization Policy research, notably Albrecht and Bishara (2018) at the Project on Middle East Political Science, shows that post-2011 regimes strengthened security sectors to deter future uprisings. Across Egypt, Syria, and Algeria, resilience rests on coercive cohesion and elite control of violence.

IV. Rentierism and Economic Stabilization

Beyond coercion, authoritarian resilience in the Arab world is deeply rooted in political economy. Rentier state theory helps explain how regimes used economic tools to maintain the status quo and authoritarian rule (Hinnebusch, 2015). Authoritarian resilience in the Arab world is firmly anchored in political economy and goes beyond repression. In the rentier state theory, governments that receive a sizable portion of their revenue from external rents, especially hydrocarbons, can lessen social pressure for representation. According to Hazem Beblawi (1987), rentier regimes produce a distributive political economy as opposed to a productive one. By distributing externally generated wealth, the state builds a social contract based on allocation rather than representation, weakening demands for democratic accountability. This is made clear in the Gulf monarchies. In Saudi Arabia, Qatar, or the United Arab Emirates, oil and gas revenue finance the vast majority of the economy but also employment and infrastructure projects. Citizens benefit from low taxation and generous state

provision, reducing incentives for sustained political mobilization. At the same time, these regimes have pursued selective social liberalization; for instance, since 2011, they expanded women's employment, invested in cultural industries, and promoted modernization narratives, but, without conceding meaningful political pluralism. Social opening thus coexists with political closure.

Rentierism serves an essential political role: it secures loyalty among the elite and funds ruling coalitions. Oil revenues do not simply procure social stability; they also shape elite negotiations. As evidenced by Michael Herb (2014) in his analysis of Kuwait and the UAE, resource wealth enables ruling families to integrate merchant groups, tribal leaders, and bureaucratic elites into the political framework. They do this through patronage, public sector jobs, and access to government contracts. Consequently, the distribution of rents stabilizes internal elite relations and diminishes the motivation for defection. Consistent with broader authoritarian power theories, control over economic rents allows rulers to monopolize critical resources and avert fragmentation within the governing coalition. However, this framework is susceptible to structural pressures. The significant drop in global oil prices after 2014 severely restricted the budgets of Gulf states and revealed the financial vulnerabilities of rent-dependent regimes. In Saudi Arabia, the introduction and subsequent tripling of the value-added tax in 2020 signified a substantial transformation in the distributive social agreement. When governments that historically refrained from taxation start to extract revenue directly from the populace, the implicit agreement underpinning rentier authoritarianism is fundamentally changed. While elevated energy prices might temporarily ease fiscal challenges, long-term sustainability remains questionable, especially in light of population growth and ambitious economic diversification initiatives. The situation in Yemen exemplifies the limitations of resilience in rentier systems. As oil revenues dwindled and political fragmentation increased, the state experienced a loss of both distributive ability and coercive unity. Rather than fostering political reform, the depletion of rents—combined with civil conflict—led to state disintegration. Yemen shows that while rents sustain authoritarian stability, their absence does not produce democratization but institutional collapse. Rentierism strengthens authoritarian rule through welfare distribution, patronage, and elite cohesion, yet it depends on continued external revenues. Economic instability therefore represents a structural risk to rent-based regimes. Ultimately, variations in ruling systems help explain regime survival and elite cohesion across MENA.

V. Clientelism and Elite Coalition Management

While we can argue that rentierism, and the rentier-state system, ensure economic stability for the elite, clientelism goes even further. It organizes the maintenance of loyalty within the system, which is a fundamental condition for the resilience of authoritarian regimes. Authoritarian governments in the Arab region do not persist solely through oppression or petroleum profits; they last by effectively managing coalitions among the elite. The principal method involved is not merely coercion, but the calculated allocation of access to government resources to hinder division among the elite. The research of Michel Camau is particularly insightful in this context. Camau states that Arab authoritarian regimes possess a unique ability for regulated adaptation: they reorganize alliances among elites and

redistribute assets to mitigate threats without changing the fundamental power dynamics. In this way, authoritarianism is not fixed; rather, it is continually adjusted to maintain unity among the elite. Lebanon can be used as a case study to show how sectarian elite networks uphold elite cohesion. Political figures allocate employment in the public sector, government contracts, and social services via confessional channels. Although the protests in 2019 challenged the issues of corruption and sectarian clientelism, the ruling elite ultimately sustained the power-sharing arrangement. Instead of reforming the system itself, elites retained their collective authority by re-negotiating access to state resources in response to societal challenges. In Morocco, the monarchy demonstrates a form of regulated pluralism. Although political parties engage in electoral competition, the central power is ultimately held by the palace. Through mechanisms of patronage, selective appointments, and economic incentives, the monarchy incorporates party leaders and business elites into its ruling coalition. The constitutional changes enacted following the 2011 uprisings alleviated social unrest while maintaining the preeminence of the monarchy. By keeping control over significant economic and institutional assets, the monarchy curbed elite divisions while maintaining an appearance of reform.

In a similar fashion, Jordan depends on tribal patronage systems to maintain regime stability. Employment in the public sector, military roles, and state resources are allocated to supportive constituencies, particularly those within East Bank tribes. This arrangement helps to reduce the likelihood of elite desertion during times of economic difficulty. In both Egypt and Syria, the elite's control over economic and repressive resources further entrenches authoritarian governance. In Egypt, the military's authority over crucial economic fields bolsters internal cohesion within the ruling coalition. In Syria, loyalist networks situated within security entities manage the distribution of influence and wealth. In both scenarios, the resilience of authoritarianism is a result of the monopolization of vital resources and the enduring stability of elite partnerships.

In all cases, the same pattern emerges : the survival of authoritarianism relies on the cohesion of elite groups, ranging from the re-allocation of state assets and the incorporation of adversaries to the strategic use of institutional frameworks, and discord within the leadership. Consequently, clientelism should be viewed not as a weakness, but rather as a crucial mechanism for the longevity of authoritarian regimes and adaptation to different contexts.

VI. Authoritarian Upgrading and Adaptation

Arab governments have progressively depended on the enhancement of authoritarian practices to address social pressures and maintain long-term dominance. As articulated by Steven Heydemann in 2007 and 2013, this enhancement of authoritarianism entails the tactical modernization of repression and governance strategies, enabling these governments to evolve without reallocating fundamental power. Prominent methods consist of regulated elections, legalistic suppression, non-governmental organization oversight, and selective reforms. The primary goal is stability rather than the promotion of democracy. In Egypt, laws pertaining to cybercrime, along with stringent regulations governing NGOs, criminalize autonomous activism while creating a legal veneer for repression. In a similar vein,

Morocco's constitutional amendments and multiparty elections fabricate a semblance of political diversity, yet genuine power continues to reside with the monarchy. Monarchies in the Gulf region, such as the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, merge modernization narratives—like women's participation in the workforce and cultural growth—with extensive digital surveillance capabilities, encompassing AI-driven monitoring and internet censorship, to govern public discourse. Following the conflict in Syria, post-war reconstruction allocates resources to loyalist factions, thereby consolidating authority through resource and demographic manipulation. A significant advancement within this context is the rise of digital authoritarianism and transnational repression. Regimes are increasingly monitoring online dissent and targeting adversaries internationally. The assassination of Jamal Khashoggi in Istanbul exemplifies the far-reaching nature of this coercive power, highlighting that authoritarian governance extends beyond national limitations. The enhancement of authoritarian practices illustrates that resilience within the Arab region is both dynamic and adaptive. Through the integration of legal frameworks, regulated political plurality, digital oversight, and international repression, these governments adjust power dynamics to face evolving challenges. This adaptability ensures that authoritarianism is not only persistent but also becoming more intricate, capable of managing societal expectations and elite demands while averting fragmentation and transitions toward democracy.

VII. Arab Spring Revisited

The 2011 Arab Spring represented the most important wave of mass mobilization across the Middle-East and North Africa, which raised questions about the durability of authoritarianism. However, as noted by Brownlee, Masoud, and Reynolds (2015) and Albrecht and Bishara (2018), outcomes varied significantly due to differences in coercive unity, financial resources, and leadership governance.Analyzing these differences comparatively elucidates the reasons behind the collapse of certain regimes, the endurance of others, and the mere adjustments made by a select few. In Tunisia, the presence of weak institutions, fragmented unity forces, and the government inability to sustain loyalty through rewards or coercion, contributed to the collapse. In Syria, powerful coercive institutions combined with scarce resources resulted in a violent survival of the regime. Loyalist networks and outside backing from Russia and Iran stopped elite defections and suppressed social movements. The Gulf monarchies represent a unique case of apparent stability: they enjoy substantial revenue and strong enforcement systems, which allowed them to remain stable. The distribution of resources to supporters, along with the inclusion of elites, reduced the chances of public protests even when there was unrest in the region. In Algeria, powerful enforcement bodies permitted changes among elites without leading to the fall of the government, showing how authoritarian systems can adapt to large-scale protests while keeping their main frameworks intact.

The comparative findings strengthen an essential point: mass mobilization poses a risk to authoritarian governments only when elite groups break apart and enforcement agencies turn away from the regime—this scenario is uncommon. Yemen serves as a notable example where both internal division and outside involvement slowed down the strength of authoritarian rule, but in the end, it resulted in the collapse of the state instead of democratic

progress. In summary, the Arab Spring illustrates that the ability to resist is influenced not solely by social oppression or economic benefits on their own but by the mix of strong enforcement systems, stability among elites, and control over resources. While mobilization can threaten authoritarian governance, without cracks in elite unity and defections, these regimes are likely to endure, adjust, and even strengthen their power afterward.

VIII. Conclusion :

In a nutshell, our analysis demonstrates that authoritarian resilience in the Arab region is not a product of cultural determinism, nor inherent to all regional societies. Instead, it is the result of structural, economic, and institutional mechanisms that nip in the bud all demands for structural change and political opening. Cohesive coercive state structures and military forces, enable governments to keep the monopoly of violence, and prevent the 'instability', meaning, eminent members leaving the apparatus, as evidenced in Syria, Egypt, and Algeria. Economies that depend on rentier resources create mechanisms of support, and, with the integration of economic and political elites, maintain allegiance through financial aid, social services and favoritism, through sectarian networks. This helps reinforce dictatorial power by concentrating essential resources, consolidating key political actors within the government, reducing the risk of division and implosion. Therefore, the authoritarian upgrading is essential allowing the regime not only to survive but also to adapt to social pressures, adopting controlled elections, legal repression, and digital surveillance, while purposefully engaging supportive groups. That is why if four leaders were evicted from power, the political landscape was marked by a re-consolidation of authoritarian regimes (Egypt or Bahrain) rather than democratic transitions (Libya, Yémen or Syria). Digital authoritarianism expands control through AI surveillance, online censorship, and transnational repression, exemplified by targeting opposition abroad. Regional cooperation, such as GCC intervention in Bahrain (2011) and Egypt-Saudi-UAE counter-revolutionary alliances post-2013, reinforces regime survival. Yet resilience is conditional: economic crises, demographic pressures, or elite fragmentation could destabilize entrenched regimes. While digital tools and alliances aid short-term endurance, they cannot replace fiscal stability or cohesive leadership. Authoritarianism in the Arab world is adaptive but vulnerable, relying on coercion, economic rents, clientelist networks, and strategic adaptation, with its continuation ultimately uncertain.

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